

Sperm whales, like the one shown here, have huge heads and a full set of teeth along the inside of their long jaws. Colonial whalers frequently hunted this type of whale, venturing far out to sea to search for them. The oil of these whales burned more brightly than other whale oils and made finer candles, which became important export items.

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1.1 Harvesting Land and Sea

In 17th-century New England, you basically had two choices: toil day and night as a farmer, or toil day and night as a sailor. Neither option left much time for anything else.

MAIN IDEA New England's colonial economy was based on agriculture, commerce, and small-scale manufacturing.

FARMING HILLY, ROCKY LAND

Most New England colonists were farmers. Their farms were small and were frequently located on hilly and forested land with rocky soil. The long, cold winters made for a short growing season.

Farmers relied on their large families to clear the fields, plant and harvest the crops, and care for the farm animals. This all added up to something called **subsistence farming**. This means the farmers produced about enough food to provide for their family with only a little, if any, left over to sell or trade. In other words, they were barely scraping by. Without much in savings or extra food, a poor year of farming could ruin a family.

Because farming was so tough, the size and quality of a family's farmland mattered. Colonists were at the mercy of their town's powerful Puritan founders, who led the church and the town. The founders decided the location and amount of land a family received. One man might be given 50 acres with grazing fields attached, another only 3 acres with grazing fields a mile away. It wasn't fair, and these differences in land ownership created distinct social classes within the town.



Harpoon
Whalers used harpoons to stun and capture their prey. Sailors launched whaleboats from the ship, surrounded the whale, and threw their weapons. Once the whale was fully pierced by harpoons, which were attached to ropes, the sailors towed the huge animal back to the ship.

FISHING, WHALING, AND TRADE

The Atlantic Ocean provided greater economic opportunities than agriculture. Colonial fishers could engage in international trade, selling their catch to London merchants in exchange for goods such as shoes, textiles, and metal products. Whaling provided the colonists with many commercial products, including whale oils and waxes, meat, fat, bones, and leather. Colonists sold and exported the whale meat and blubber, or fat. People used the blubber to light oil lamps, make candles, and soften leather.

Fishing and whaling led to the growth of a shipbuilding industry. New England's plentiful forests supplied the shipyards with timber—and employment. Building a single ship could employ 200 workers. Shipbuilders also kept sawmills, rope makers, and iron foundries busy. By the end of the 1700s, New England built one-third of all British ships and almost all of its own merchants' and fishers' ships. This economic activity made New England a natural center of colonial trade.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What four economic activities were important in New England?
2. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** What conclusion can you draw about the relationship between a family's farm and its social class?
3. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** In what ways were the goods provided by the Atlantic Ocean essential to the livelihood, economy, and culture of the New England colonists?

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